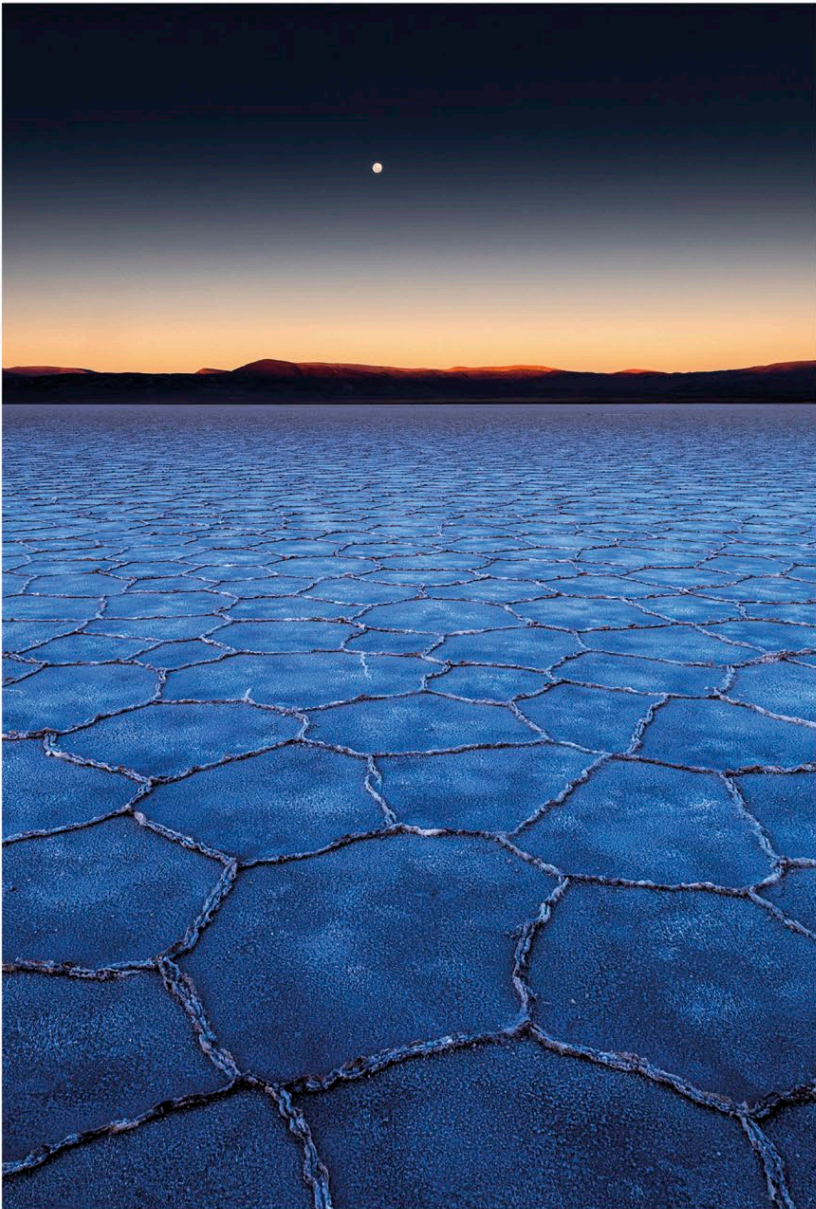


The Caatinga

Location Northeast Brazil

This vast ecoregion covers almost 10 percent of Brazil’s territory, some 328,000 square miles (850,000 square km) of drought-resistant shrubland and thorn forest. The Caatinga experiences two seasons: a very hot dry season, when soil temperatures may reach 140°F (60°C) and plants drop their leaves to reduce transpiration; and a shorter, hot rainy season. After the first rain falls, the cerrado transforms in just a few days from a dead-looking grayish landscape to one that is bright green and full of life.



▲ HEXAGONAL PATTERNS AT SALINAS GRANDES SALT DESERT

Salar de Arizaro

Location Puna de Atacama, northwest Argentina

The world’s sixth largest salt flat covers 600 square miles (1,600 square km) and lies at an elevation of about 11,350 ft (3,460 m) in the Andes. Formed as a result of the evaporation of surface water and the deposition of its constituent salts, Salar de Arizaro also features yardangs (ridges of rock aligned with the prevailing northwesterly winds), rocks that have been weathered by the repeated growth of salt crystals, relic lake shores, and

the small volcanic cone of Cono de Arita, which rises about 390 ft (120 m) above the salt.

Talampaya National Park

Location La Rioja province, northwest Argentina

This World Heritage Site protects 830 square miles (2,150 square km) of arid scrub desert in the rain shadow of the Andes mountains. The Talampaya National Park includes dramatic landscapes shaped by water and wind, including the 469-ft- (143-m-) deep Talampaya Gorge and many red sandstone cliffs. The area’s main claim to fame is its fossils—the most complete known range of life forms dating from 250–200 million years ago, including the early dinosaur *Eoraptor* and mammals, fish, amphibians, and plants.

Salinas Grandes

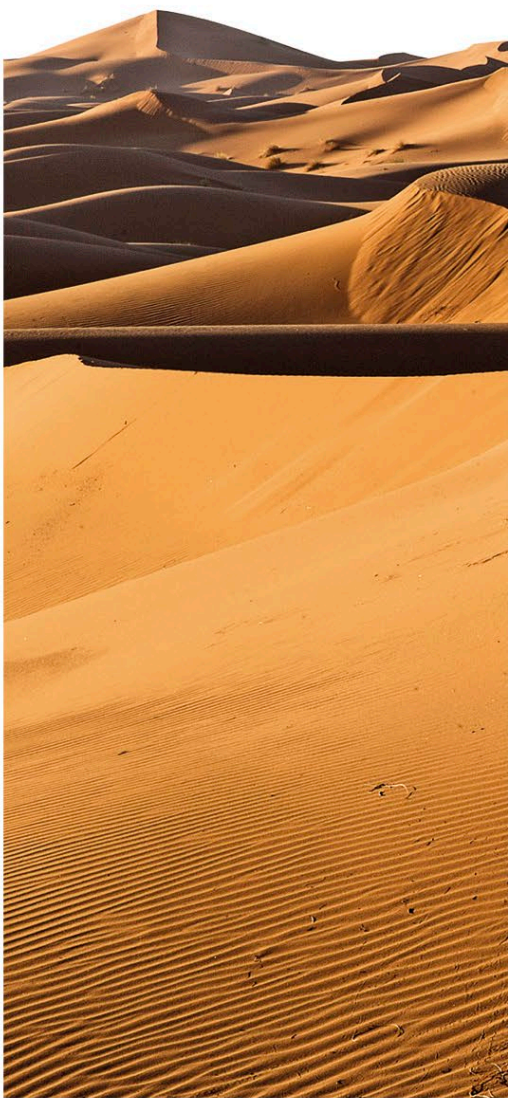
Location Jujuy and Salta provinces, Puna de Atacama, northwest Argentina

This large salt flat lies at the bottom of an endorheic basin (one with no outlet) at an elevation of 10,990 ft (3,350 m) on the arid Andean puna. Its dazzling white salt deposits, which cover more than 120 miles (200 km), were precipitated from evaporated runoff from the surrounding mountains. Rectangular pools of water mark places where salt extraction is taking place, and local artisans carve salt figures to demonstrate their skills.

Other deserts in Central and South America

- The Atacama Desert » pp.124–25
- The Patagonian Desert » p.127
- The Salar de Uyuni » p.126
- The Valle de la Luna » p.127

▼ LARGE DUNES AT THE ERG CHEBBI



Europe

The Tabernas Desert

Location Almeria, Andalucía, southern Spain

Protected from humid winds coming from the Mediterranean by the Sierra de Alhamilla, this area of 110 square miles (280 square km) is semiarid rather than a true desert. Annual rainfall of 6–9 in (150–220 mm) is restricted to a few days. Occasional torrential rain has cut steep-sided gullies, whose river beds are usually dry, and natural underground pipes, through which water permeates below the surface at the top of a slope, passes underground, and